



UEFA Conference League trophy, and now the title of Club World Cup champion.

Chelsea's journey to the club football summit was marked by strong performances, a favourable draw, and the mid-tournament acquisition of an 80 million USD striker (Joao Pedro). It overcame LAFC, ES Tunis, Benfica, Palmeiras, and Fluminense to reach the final, bouncing back despite a 3-1 group stage loss to Flamengo.

Maresca outwits Enrique

To defeat PSG's previously irrepressible team represents a spectacular achievement for a Chelsea side that had been largely unfancied before the start of the tournament. Cole Palmer (**facing page**) was the hero of the night for the Premier League club and went on to win the Player of the Tournament award. The 23-year-old bagged a brace and set up another for Joao Pedro as the Blues became the first English side to lift the trophy twice after winning the 2021 edition.

Having played on the left of Chelsea's attack and as a drifting No. 10 this season, Palmer started on the right flank as Maresca looked to expose a chink in the armour of Luis Enrique's side. The selfless running of striker Pedro and wing-back Malo Gusto was integral to Palmer's punishing performance — either running in behind to create space or pushing to that flank to ensure there were bodies around him.

The Parisian side was uncharacteristically disjointed throughout the match, with its stars failing to make an impact. Maresca's tactical prowess was evident as he expertly outmanoeuvred Enrique. Chelsea's defence, anchored by a five-man backline, employed a low block to effectively stifle PSG's normally free-flowing attack.

Adding to Chelsea's heroics, goalkeeper Robert Sanchez delivered a world-class performance, making a series of crucial saves that repeatedly thwarted PSG's attempts to get back into the game and dashed any hopes of a comeback for the French giant.

Jubilant: Chelsea captain Reece James (holding trophy) and coach Enzo Maresca (25) celebrate with the team.

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A glimpse into football's future

Since a Clearlake Capital-led consortium acquired Chelsea from Roman Abramovich for USD 3.2 billion in May 2022, the club has invested nearly USD 1.89 billion on over 45 players across six transfer windows.

This period has been tumultuous for the London club, but the CWC win suggests Chelsea may finally be heading towards a more consistent future. In the end, the final of a season-ending tournament boasting a USD 1 billion prize pool encapsulated the state of the game in 2025.

This was a clash between a club backed by a Qatari sovereign wealth fund and another owned primarily by an American private equity firm — two of the three highest-spending clubs in global football over the past decade.